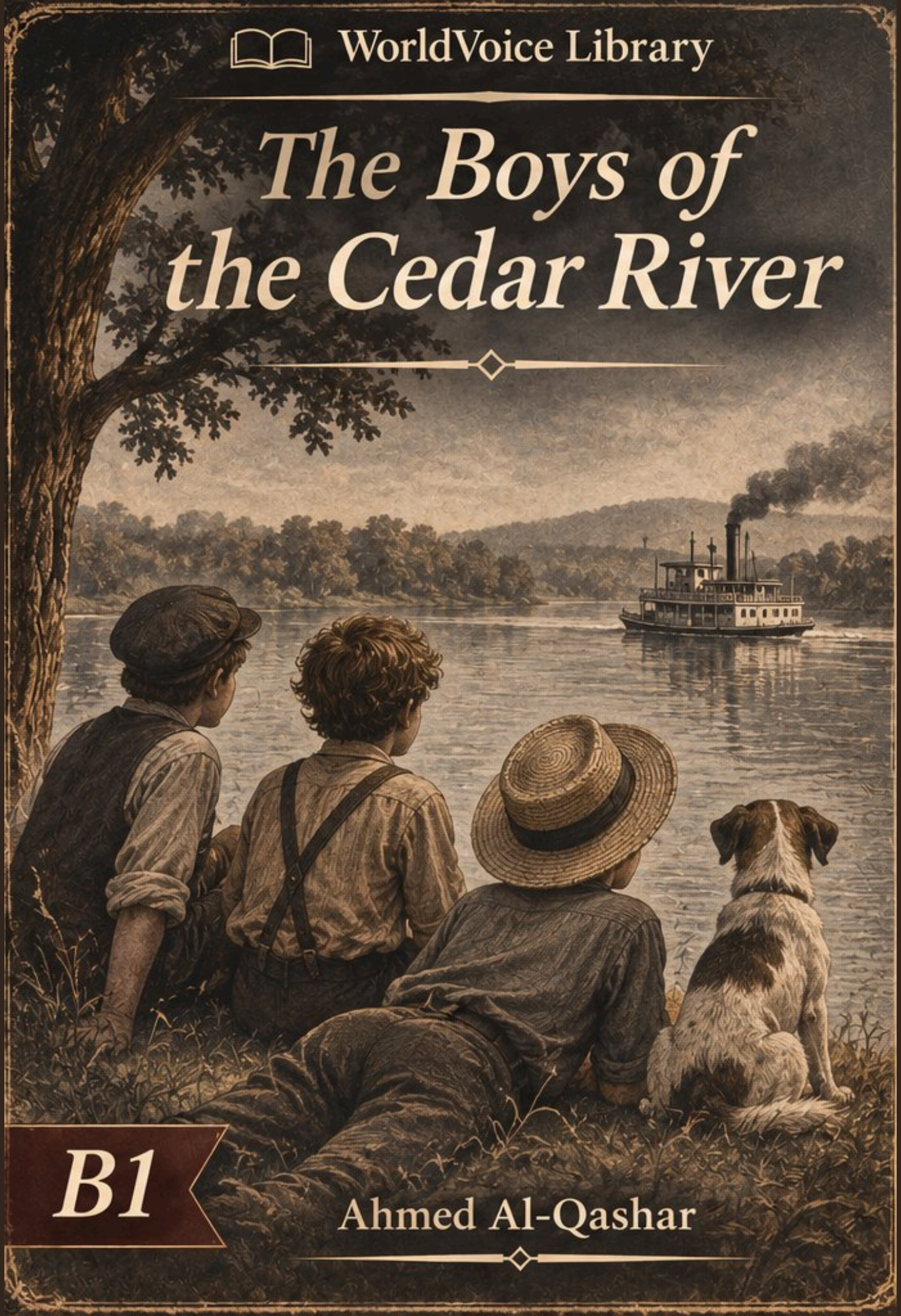

WorldVoice Library
The Boys of the Cedar River
B1
Ahmed Al-Qashar

WorldVoice Library

The Boys of the Cedar River

An Adventure Mystery Story

Ahmed Al-Qashar

English Graded Reader · B1 Intermediate

Ten illustrated chapters · Original historical fiction

Set in a fictional American river town, 1857

Publication & Rights

The Boys of the Cedar River is an original fictional graded reader for WorldVoice Library. Written by Ahmed Al-Qashar.

Copyright © 2026 Ahmed Al-Qashar. All rights reserved.

This story takes place in the fictional American river town of Bellwater in 1857. The characters, the Cedar River, Cinder Island, and the fictional businesses and events in this story are not claims about identifiable historical people or places.

Historical background: nineteenth-century river towns relied on ferries, steamboats, river landings, and mills to transport people and goods. These general details provide historical atmosphere; the novel itself is fictional.

Educational edition for learners of English at the B1 (Intermediate) level. This is an intended reading level, not an independent language certification.

No ISBN has been assigned to this edition.

Story Introduction

Bellwater is a busy town beside the Cedar River in the year 1857. Steamboats carry passengers and goods through its winding channels. Along its banks live farmers, sailors, workers, and families who depend on the river every day.

One afternoon, Leo Marsh and his friends discover a boat that should not be there. Its owner, the old ferryman Elias Wren, disappeared weeks ago. Inside the boat is an unfinished warning, a strange little brass tube, and a mystery that leads toward an island hidden by trees.

What begins as a summer adventure becomes a search for someone the town has almost forgotten. The friends must learn whom to trust, how to protect each other, and why one small fact can change an entire story.

Before You Read

1. Would you keep a mysterious note you found in an abandoned boat? Why?

2. What jobs did people do on large rivers before cars and modern roads?

3. How can a group of friends make safer choices when they face danger?

Contents

Publication & Rights 3

Story Introduction 4

Characters 6

Chapter 1 The Boat That Came Back 7

Chapter 2 Three Knocks at the Landing 12

Chapter 3 The Map Beneath the Flour 17

Chapter 4 A Stranger on the Morning Star 22

Chapter 5 The Island with Two Names 27

Chapter 6 The Man with the Silver Watch 31

Chapter 7 The Night the River Rose 35

Chapter 8 The Locked Warehouse 40

Chapter 9 The Bells of Bellwater 45

Chapter 10 A Promise at Daybreak 49

Glossary (40 Words) 54

Reading Check 56

Discuss and Write 57

Characters



Leo Marsh

A curious young boy who wants to discover why Elias Wren disappeared.



Finn Alder

Careful with tools and details. He writes down clues and checks the facts.



Toby

A brave friend with a quick joke, even on the most difficult days.

N

Nora Finch

A clever girl from the bakery who understands the old river maps.



Patch

The friends' loyal dog. He notices danger before anyone else.

I

The Boat That Came Back

The first strange thing happened on a Tuesday afternoon, when the river returned a boat that everyone believed had been lost.

Leo Marsh saw it before anyone else. He was standing at the edge of Bellwater Landing, holding a piece of bread in one hand and trying to keep a wet dog out of Mrs. Pike's washing in the other. The dog, Patch, had already stolen a sock. Leo knew that a second sock would be too much for Mrs. Pike's good nature.

"Patch! Bring that back!" he called.

Patch looked at Leo, made the serious face of a dog considering an important question, and ran toward the river.

"A wonderful animal," said Toby Reed, who was sitting on an empty barrel. "He understands every word you say. Then he does the opposite."

Toby was fourteen and believed that food was the answer to most problems. At present he had a small apple pie hidden inside his coat. No one knew how it had arrived there. Leo suspected that Toby's mother would be looking for it at supper.

Finn Alder came down the wooden steps from the road. He was carrying a notebook and a short length of rope. Finn liked to measure things, repair things, and ask questions that made other people uncomfortable.

"The wind changed after noon," Finn said. "See the small waves? They're moving against the current."

"Good," Toby replied. "Perhaps the river will bring us dinner."

Then Leo saw the boat.

It was a narrow, green rowing boat, moving slowly beside the reeds. One oar was missing. Its bow pointed upstream, as if someone invisible were pulling it backward. A dark line ran across the wood near the front.

"That looks like Mr. Wren's boat," Leo whispered.

Elias Wren had worked on the Cedar River for more than thirty years. He knew every dangerous bend and every shallow place. Three weeks earlier, he had disappeared after taking a small boat out in the evening. Some people said he had fallen into the river. Others said he had stolen money from the workers who were repairing Bellwater Bridge and had escaped to another town.

Leo did not believe either story. Mr. Wren had once pulled him from deep water. He had also spent three hours teaching Finn how to mend a broken fishing net, although Finn had asked so many questions that any ordinary man would have given up.

"It's his," Finn said. He pointed to the black stripe along the side. "I helped him paint that stripe last spring."

The boys dragged a long pole from under the landing and caught the boat before it reached the faster current. Patch barked while they pulled. He seemed pleased to be in charge of a rescue that required no swimming.

Inside the boat they found mud, a broken cup, and a cloth bag tied to the seat. The bag was dry, even though the bottom of the boat was wet.

"A treasure bag," Toby announced.

"Or a bag of old nails," said Finn.

Leo opened it. There was no gold. There was a small brass whistle, a piece of folded paper, and a silver button with an oak leaf pressed into its surface.

The paper smelled of river water and tobacco. The words had been written carefully, but the final line ended suddenly:



When the river holds its breath, look where the cedars lean. Do not trust the man who—

Below the unfinished sentence was a rough drawing of two trees and three short lines. On the other side someone had written the number **17**.

"That is either a very bad letter," Toby said, "or a very good mystery."

Finn examined the button. "This is not from Mr. Wren's coat. He wore wooden buttons."

"How can you remember a man's buttons?" asked Toby.

"How can you remember the price of every pie in town?"

"That is important information."

Leo barely heard them. He was watching a man across the road. The stranger stood under the sign of the Riverside Store, half-hidden by the shade. He wore a dark coat despite the warm weather. When Leo looked at him, the man turned away.

"We should take this to Sheriff Bell," Finn said.

Leo folded the paper and put it safely in his shirt. "Maybe. But first I want to know why Mr. Wren's boat has returned without him."

A bell sounded from the church above the landing. Three slow notes. The boys stepped back from the river as the *Morning Star*, the largest steamboat on the Cedar,

passed the far bank. Smoke rose from its tall black chimney. A few passengers leaned on the rail, enjoying the evening air.

Patch suddenly gave a low growl. He was not watching the boat. He was watching the dark-coated man, who had come closer to the landing.

"Is that your boat?" the man called.

Leo said nothing.

"I asked you a question."

"It belongs to the river," Toby answered cheerfully. "And the river has not shown us the papers."

The stranger did not smile. His eyes moved from Leo's shirt to the brass whistle in Finn's hand.

"Some things that wash ashore are better left alone," he said.

Then he walked up the hill, slowly enough to look calm, but quickly enough that his boots struck the steps like little hammers.

For a moment nobody spoke. Finally Finn took his notebook from his pocket and wrote down the time.

"Why are you doing that?" Leo asked.

"Because," Finn said, "people tell stories later. Times do not change as easily as stories."

Toby pulled the apple pie from his coat and broke it into four pieces. He gave the smallest to Patch. The dog swallowed it without thanks.

"All right," Toby said. "We have a missing man, a boat that came home, and a stranger who hates boats. That's enough work for one afternoon."

Leo looked again at the unfinished sentence. The words *Do not trust the man who—* seemed darker in the falling light.

"Not enough," he replied. "Tomorrow we find out what the river is trying to tell us."

That night Leo placed the whistle beside his bed. Just before he fell asleep, he remembered something strange. The whistle had no hole for a sound. It was not a whistle at all. It was a tiny metal tube with a screw at one end.

And inside it, something moved.

II

Three Knocks at the Landing

Finn opened the little brass tube with a pair of careful fingers the next morning. Leo and Toby stood beside him in the Alder family's workshop, breathing over his shoulder until Finn pushed them away.

"If you want to help," he said, "stop moving the table."

The screw was stiff. Finn wrapped it in cloth and turned it with a small tool. At last it came free. A thin strip of paper fell out, rolled so tightly that it looked like a pale worm.

There were just four words on it: *Listen for three knocks.*

"Three knocks on what?" Leo asked.

"A door?" said Finn.

"A dinner table?" Toby suggested. "I can test that one at once."

Their laughter stopped when Finn pointed at a small mark on the paper. It was the same oak leaf stamped on the silver button.

The boys decided to visit Bellwater Landing after sunset. First, however, they needed a boat of their own. Mr. Wren's had a split board near the bottom, and Leo was unwilling to trust his friends to a boat that might sink. Finn found a narrow skiff behind his father's workshop. It had belonged to his older brother and needed only one repaired seat and a fresh rope.

"My father won't mind us using it in daylight," Finn said. "At night he might have questions."

"Parents always do," Toby said. "Mine asked why an entire pie had disappeared yesterday. It was a very personal question."

At noon, while they were repairing the skiff, a girl appeared at the gate. She was fifteen, with a blue scarf tied around her hair and a basket under one arm. Her name was Nora Finch. Her family kept the small bakery beside the church. Nora could calculate prices without paper and remembered almost everything she read.

"I hear you found a boat," she said.

Toby looked guilty. "I did not steal another pie."

"I wasn't asking about pie. I was asking about Elias Wren."

Leo looked up. "What do you know?"

Nora set down her basket. "Mr. Wren came into our shop the morning he vanished. He bought two rolls and asked my father whether the old north landing was still used. The north landing has been closed for ten years. Why would he want to go there?"

"Maybe he wanted to be alone," Finn replied.

"He also left this." Nora took out a scrap of paper and showed them a list of numbers. "It was under the money he paid with. My father thought it was a receipt."

The numbers ran down the page in two columns: 4, 8, 12, 17, 21. Opposite them were short marks that looked like small trees.

"Seventeen again," Leo said.

Nora noticed his surprise. "Again?"

The boys told her about the boat and the brass tube. They left out the dark-coated stranger until they knew whether she believed them. Nora listened without interrupting, then pulled the strip of paper closer.



"These aren't prices," she said. "My grandfather drew river measurements this way. The numbers might be distances from the old stone marker."

Finn sat up. "The marker at the north landing?"

"Exactly. And if someone told Mr. Wren to go there, perhaps he went to check something."

The boys exchanged a look. Nora had solved more in two minutes than they had solved all morning.

"You should come with us," Leo said.

"Of course I should," she replied. "You'd probably sail in the wrong direction without me."

They agreed to meet at twilight, but they did not leave until Nora had made them promise one thing: if they saw armed men or signs of danger, they would return and tell Sheriff Bell. No secret was worth someone's life.

The north landing stood beyond a field of tall grass, where the river curved behind a wall of dark cedars. Its wooden platform had fallen into the water in several places. A round stone, almost buried in weeds, marked the place where boats once stopped.

They reached it as the evening light faded. Finn tied the skiff to a sound post. Patch went ashore first, sniffing every root.

"We're here," Toby said. "Would somebody like to knock?"

Nothing happened. Then, from far across the river, they heard three hollow taps.

Knock. Knock. Knock.

The sounds came again. This time Leo saw a brief light among the trees on the opposite bank. It disappeared and then shone once more.

"Someone is signalling," Nora whispered.

Finn counted the pauses on his fingers. "Three knocks, one light, two lights."

A second light answered from the steamboat landing farther downstream.

"That isn't Mr. Wren," Nora said. "He'd use the ferry bell, not a signal like that."

The four friends dropped behind the broken platform as footsteps crossed the grass. Two men came out of the shadows. One wore the dark coat Leo had seen the day before. The other carried a wooden box.

"The tide doesn't matter here," the second man said. "It's the water level. When the current slows, the hidden channel opens."

"And the book?" the dark-coated man asked.

"Still missing. Rusk won't pay until he has it."

Leo held his breath. The men walked past them, so close that Patch's nose followed the movement of their boots. Nora gently placed a hand over the dog's collar.

The men stopped beside the stone marker. One bent down and tapped the stone three times with a metal tool. Under the weeds a square wooden door lifted open. It covered a narrow storage pit beside the landing.

"There it is," whispered Finn.

The second man put the box inside. Then the strangers left along the bank toward town.

No one moved until the footsteps had faded. When Nora lifted the lid again, the pit smelled of damp earth. They found a sack of coal, two empty lanterns, and a receipt marked with the words *Bellwater Bridge — Payment Number 17*.

The receipt listed the names of six workers. Beside every name stood the word *Paid*. Leo knew two of those men. Neither had received his wages.

"Someone is writing false receipts," Nora said.

"And Mr. Wren knew," Leo added.

Above them a distant horn sounded. The *Morning Star* was approaching the bend. Through the trees they could see her windows shining against the water.

Suddenly Patch barked toward the path. The dark-coated man had returned. He stood at the top of the bank, looking straight at the open pit.

"I told you," he said, "to leave the river alone."

III

The Map Beneath the Flour

Leo did not run. He wanted to, but the path behind him was narrow and the river was close. If one friend slipped, the others might fall on top of him.

"We're looking for a lost dog," he said.

Patch barked, offended by this explanation.

The stranger stepped down the bank. "You've found him, then. Go home."

Nora stood up with the empty basket on her arm. "And you've found the old landing. Is there a reason you're here after dark, Mr. Cale?"

Leo turned to her in surprise. She knew the man.

"I'm checking the river stores," he replied.

"For whom?" Nora asked.

"That is no business of yours."

Nora tilted her head. "My father says that people who have honest answers usually give them."

For the first time the stranger seemed uncertain. He stepped toward the stone marker, and Finn quietly pushed the receipt into his notebook. Toby moved between Patch and the stranger with an empty hand held up.

"We were just leaving," Toby said. "I haven't had supper, and that is a serious danger in itself."

Cale watched them climb into the skiff. He did not follow, but his dark shape remained at the landing until they crossed the bend and could no longer see him.

"You shouldn't have said his name," Leo told Nora.

"Why not? It's Edwin Cale. He works for Thomas Rusk, the shipping merchant. Half the town knows him."

"The other half probably wishes it didn't," Toby said.

The next day they met in the bakery before the first customers arrived. Nora's father had gone to deliver bread. Flour covered the long wooden table, and the warm smell of fresh rolls filled the room.

Nora unfolded the numbered paper. "Grandfather used to keep maps under the sacks so they wouldn't curl in the damp. He worked as a river surveyor before he became a baker. Let's see what he left."

From a high shelf she took a flat wooden drawer filled with old plans. Toby reached for a roll, and Nora slapped his hand lightly with a clean cloth.

"When the mystery is solved," she said.

"You drive a hard bargain."



The fourth plan was a map of the Cedar River made thirty years before. It showed Bellwater Town, the bridge, the north landing, and a narrow channel passing behind an island marked *Cinder Island*. The island's name had been crossed out. Above it someone had written *Wren's Rest*.

"Mr. Wren named it?" Finn asked.

"Possibly," Nora said. "But look at these numbers."

Small figures ran beside the channel: 4, 8, 12, 17, 21. They matched the paper Mr. Wren had left in the bakery.

"They're depths," Finn said. "Feet of water at different points. The channel was once deep enough for a narrow boat."

"And now?" Leo asked.

"Now it may be hidden beneath the reeds. Look at the date. The river changed its course after the flood of 1848."

Nora spread another sheet across the table. On it was a drawing of a fallen cedar leaning over a low stone wall. Underneath someone had written: *Watch the shadow when the current rests.*

Leo took out the unfinished letter from Mr. Wren's boat. *When the river holds its breath, look where the cedars lean.*

"They're instructions for finding the old channel," he said. "The water slows at the bend during the low-water hour."

"Perhaps," Finn said. "But we need to know when that happens. The wind, the rain, the height of the river—"

"We need to know whether breakfast is available," Toby interrupted.

Nora handed him a roll. He looked so grateful that Patch sat beside him with deep interest.

That afternoon Finn went to ask his father about the channel. Leo visited the bridge workers. Several said they had been promised pay weeks earlier. One man, Joseph Dyer, showed Leo a signed note from Thomas Rusk's office. The note claimed his money had already been given to Elias Wren for delivery.

"Wren never brought it," Joseph said sadly. "And now no one knows where he went."

Leo asked whether he believed Mr. Wren had stolen it. Joseph looked at the river before answering.

"I believed it yesterday. Today I am not sure. I knew Elias for twenty years. He never kept even a lost button if he could find its owner."

By evening the friends had learned three things. The unpaid workers were being blamed for complaining. The merchant Rusk was taking charge of the new bridge contract. And Edwin Cale had been seen carrying heavy boxes onto the *Morning Star* after dark.

"There is another part of the map," Finn said when they met by the workshop. "Father remembers a landing bell on Cinder Island. They used to ring it if a boat entered the shallow channel."

"A bell," Leo repeated. "Not a whistle."

"Don't look disappointed," Toby said. "We still have enough strange objects for a proper mystery."

Nora pointed to the drawing of the cedar. "Look at its shadow. If the sun is low behind the island, the shadow may point toward the stone wall."

"Then we go tomorrow," Leo said.

Nora shook her head. "No. We first find out what Mr. Rusk is moving on the steamboat. If he is behind the false receipts, he'll lead us to the missing book."

"And where might that book be?" asked Finn.

Nora turned over the bakery plan. On the back was a line written in her grandfather's neat hand: *Records kept in two places are harder to steal.*

They sat silently for a moment. The man they were looking for had left no clear message, but he had left a trail. Every small clue pointed toward a person clever enough to hide the truth and frightened enough to leave a way for someone else to find it.

Outside, the riverboat's horn called through the warm evening air.

"Tomorrow," Nora said, "we take a ride on the *Morning Star*."

IV

A Stranger on the Morning Star

The *Morning Star* left Bellwater at nine each morning and returned before sunset. Its upper deck had bright white rails, and a painted star shone above the wheelhouse. Passengers paid a small fare to travel as far as Willow Point, where farmers brought sacks of grain to the river.

Leo had never ridden on her. From the shore she had always looked like a floating palace. From the boarding steps she looked much larger, louder, and less willing to wait for a boy who was still deciding whether he was brave.

"You can still go home," Nora told him.

"I wasn't thinking of going home."

"You were looking toward the road."

"I was checking the weather."

"Of course you were."

Toby arrived carrying a basket of rolls and a paper bag full of cheese. He had promised to help Nora deliver the food to the boat's kitchen. The cook was an old friend of the Finch family, and she had agreed to let the children travel as far as Willow Point with her morning delivery.

Patch was less welcome. A large sign said **NO DOGS IN THE DINING ROOM**.

"He can't read," Toby explained to the sailor at the gate.

"Then you can read it to him," the sailor replied.

The dog stayed in a shaded corner of the lower deck with Finn. Leo and Nora took the rolls to the kitchen, where Mrs. Ada Quill, the cook, greeted them as though they had arrived to save a starving nation.

"You're late," she said. "The captain eats at ten, and the passengers think food grows out of the walls."

"We were only two minutes late," Toby said.

"Two minutes is how long it takes a hungry gentleman to complain six times."

She gave Toby a wooden spoon and set him to work stirring soup. Nora carried fresh bread through the dining room. Leo followed with a tray, carefully balancing cups of hot tea. He tried to walk like a proper waiter. His first step was excellent. On his second, the boat turned around a bend.

A cup slid across the tray and landed in a gentleman's hat.

The man was too surprised to be angry. Toby, watching from the doorway, made a noise like a chicken trying not to laugh.

"A most unusual service," the gentleman said, lifting his damp hat.

"It is our new river tea," Leo replied. "Very fresh."

Even Nora had to turn away.

They were still laughing when a voice behind them said, "Children should stay out of business rooms."

Edwin Cale stood at the end of the passage. He wore the same dark coat. Beside him was Thomas Rusk, a broad man with a smooth face and a silver watch hanging from his waistcoat. Rusk owned warehouses, boats, and much of the land near the bridge. He spoke softly, as though everyone was already listening to him.

"These are Mrs. Finch's children, I believe," Rusk said. "And their friends."



"We're delivering bread," Nora answered.

"Excellent. A town needs honest workers."

He looked at the basket, then at Leo's empty tray. "The lower rooms are for cargo. Be careful not to wander."

Rusk walked away. Cale followed after giving Leo a warning glance.

"The watch," Leo whispered. "Did you see it?"

"Silver," Nora replied. "With a little oak leaf engraved on the cover."

"The same leaf as the button," Finn said when they told him. "Perhaps it's the mark of his company."

The four friends worked through the busy morning while keeping their eyes open. At Willow Point they had thirty minutes before the return journey. Nora persuaded Mrs. Quill that a walk in the fresh air would improve their cooking. Mrs. Quill said she doubted it, but she let them go.

On the lower deck they saw six wooden boxes marked **TOOLS FOR BELLWATER BRIDGE**. One box had a small crack, and through the opening Leo could see folded books and bundles of paper, not hammers or nails.

"Tools for counting money," Toby murmured.

Finn examined a printed label. "These boxes were packed yesterday. The bridge office closed last week."

Footsteps sounded above them. The boys ducked behind a stack of empty barrels, while Nora stepped into view with a roll in her hand.

"Are you lost, miss?" asked a sailor.

"Only hungry," Nora said. "Do you know whether Mrs. Quill needs this taken to the wheelhouse?"

"The wheelhouse? No. Go back upstairs."

As the sailor turned to answer her, Finn slipped a loose paper from beneath the lid of the nearest box. It was a list of warehouse numbers. At the bottom someone had written **C.I. Gate 2 17**.

Nora returned, and they moved quickly toward the upper deck. But Cale was waiting beside the stairway.

"You don't listen," he said quietly.

"We listen very well," Toby replied. "We heard the captain say the soup needs less salt."

Cale reached for Finn's notebook. Leo stepped forward, but Nora put herself between them.

"If you touch him," she said, "I'll call the captain. And I'll tell her exactly where you found us."

Cale's expression changed. He glanced toward the wheelhouse, where Captain Ruth Bell was speaking to a sailor. Then he lowered his hand.

"You think this is a game," he said. "People have already been hurt."

"Where is Mr. Wren?" Leo asked.

For a moment Cale looked genuinely tired. "Go home while you still can."

He walked away without answering.

The *Morning Star* was almost ready to leave Willow Point when the boys found a note beside Patch's rope. No one had seen who put it there. The words were written on the back of an old passenger ticket:

The river does not forget its own. Ask what happened at the old mill.

"Mr. Wren?" Leo whispered.

"Or someone who wants us to think of him," Nora warned.

As the boat moved from the shore, Finn watched the sun on the water. At the first sharp turn the current seemed to slow. Between the reeds he saw a narrow, smooth strip of water leading toward distant trees.

"There," he said. "That's the hidden channel on the old map."

Leo followed the line with his eyes until it vanished behind an island.

Cinder Island was real. And somebody on the *Morning Star* wanted them to go there.

V

The Island with Two Names

They did not set out for Cinder Island without a plan. Finn checked the skiff from bow to stern, repaired a weak board, and tied a spare length of rope under the seat. Nora packed water, bread, a small medical kit, and a dry cloth for wrapping papers. Leo took the brass tube, the old map, and the receipt from the storage pit.

Toby brought two pies.

"Why two?" Nora asked.

"One for when we're frightened. The other for when we are pleased to be alive."

They left Bellwater shortly after sunrise, while the sky was pale and the air cool. The river moved quietly between tall green banks. Ducks rose from the reeds as the skiff passed. A heron stood so still in the water that Toby wondered whether it was made of painted wood.

Patch sat at the bow. He had been ordered to remain in the middle of the boat, and he had settled the matter by moving one inch at a time until his nose hung over the front.

"He will fall in," Finn said.

"Then the river will be full of dog," Toby replied.

The hidden channel did not look like a channel at all. It appeared to end in thick reeds. Finn followed the slow movement of floating leaves and steered carefully between two fallen branches. For several minutes the boat scraped the bottom. Then the water deepened, and a narrow passage opened before them.

On one side the bank was covered with young cedars. On the other stood a low wall of stone, almost hidden beneath ivy. Above the wall leaned two old trees with pale roots reaching down toward the river.

"Where the cedars lean," Nora said.

They tied the skiff to a root. Patch leaped ashore and disappeared into the brush. A moment later he returned with a dead fish, dropped it at Toby's feet, and looked proud of himself.

"A generous offer," Toby said. "But I prefer food that has stopped smelling before we eat it."

The island was larger than it appeared from the main river. A narrow path crossed through weeds to the ruins of a timber mill. The building had lost half its roof. Water had cut deep lines in the wooden floor. An iron wheel stood beside the stream, too rusted to move.

They searched the mill carefully. Finn found old marks on the wall showing how high past floods had risen. Nora found a broken lamp, a piece of blue cloth, and a cup that had been washed recently. There was no dust inside it.

"Someone was here," Leo said.



"Recently," Nora agreed.

Beyond the mill they discovered a low wooden house. Its door was open. Inside stood a table and a narrow bed made from boards. A blanket lay folded across the bed, and a candle had burned down to a black stump.

Leo's heart beat faster. He recognized a carving on the table: a fish with a square tail. Mr. Wren carved that mark on every piece of furniture he repaired.

"He stayed here," Leo said. "Perhaps he's still alive."

"If he is," Nora replied, "someone may have moved him."

Finn held the old map against the light. He placed his finger on the two trees, then drew an imaginary line from the shadow to the stone wall. By late morning, the sun had moved far enough that the shadow of the left cedar touched a loose stone at the wall's edge.

"Here," he said.

Leo and Toby pulled away the ivy. Behind it they found a small iron ring fixed to a wooden cover. The cover was heavy, and together they lifted it only a few inches. Beneath was a dry space, lined with boards.

Inside lay an oilcloth bundle. Leo opened it slowly. It held a thin notebook, several receipts, and a letter written in a familiar hand.

If you find this, I have been unable to return to Bellwater. The workers' wages were taken by men who knew the bridge accounts. I copied what I could. The main ledger is still with the man who hired them. Do not give these papers to anyone carrying the oak leaf until you know whom it serves. — Elias Wren.

For several seconds nobody spoke. Then Toby sat on a fallen stone.

"We have found his writing," he said quietly. "That means he got away from them once."

"But not necessarily forever," Nora said.

The notebook listed money paid into the bridge fund and money taken out. Some numbers were crossed through and written again. Beside Payment 17 stood the name **Thomas Rusk**. Under it was a second name: **E. Cale**.

Finn turned to the last page. Half of it had been torn away, and the remaining words were difficult to read: *The gate at the old mill is not the one they use. Under the south—*

A deep sound rolled across the island. At first Leo thought it was a distant steamboat. Then the trees shook, and a cold wind passed over the water.

"Thunder," Finn said. "A storm is coming."

They hurried toward the skiff, carrying the papers beneath Nora's coat. But when they reached the bank, the boat was gone. Only a broken piece of rope floated beside the root.

"Someone cut it," Finn said.

From the hidden channel came the sound of oars.

The friends turned and saw Edwin Cale standing in their skiff. He held the boat steady with one hand while the other rested on an oar.

"I warned you," he called. "Now put the papers on the bank."

The first drops of rain struck the water between them.

VI

The Man with the Silver Watch

Cale did not row away. He waited in the mouth of the channel while the storm moved across the sky. His face was pale, and he looked more frightened than angry.

"Those papers belong to Mr. Rusk," he said.

"No," Nora replied. "They belong to the workers whose money was taken."

"You don't understand what he's capable of."

"Then explain it," Leo said. "Tell us where Mr. Wren is."

Cale looked over his shoulder toward the open river. "I never wanted the old man hurt. I was paid to watch the boats. Nothing more."

"But you knew he was missing," Finn said.

"I knew he was alive three days ago." Cale gripped the oar. "Rusk moved him from the island when the river began to rise. I don't know where they took him after that."

A wave hit the side of the skiff. Cale shouted for them to give him the notebook, but Leo stepped back beneath the trees.

"You can take our boat," Leo said, "but you can't take the truth."

Cale stared at him. Then he reached into his coat and threw something onto the bank. It landed with a soft metal sound. "If you are foolish enough to continue, show that to Captain Bell. She's the only person on the river who might stand against Rusk."

He pushed the skiff into the channel and disappeared into the rain.

Finn picked up the object. It was a small iron key, tied to a piece of blue thread. Stamped along the side were the words **SOUTH STORE □ 2**.

"Why would he give us a key?" Toby asked.

"Because he doesn't want all of this on his conscience," Nora said. "But that doesn't make him safe to trust."

They returned to the old mill and waited beneath the strongest part of its roof. Wind drove rain through the broken windows. Thunder shook the boards, and water began to gather at the foot of the stairs.

"We need a way off this island," Finn said.

Leo remembered the marks on the wall. The highest showed where floodwater had once reached his shoulders. "And we need it soon."



Nora spread Mr. Wren's letter across a dry plank. "The south store might be in Bellwater. There is a row of warehouses below the bridge. Gate Two belongs to the largest one."

"Rusk owns it," Finn said.

Toby had been unusually silent. Now he pointed toward the old iron wheel outside the mill. "When I climbed behind that thing, I saw another boat under some boards. It looked broken, but maybe not completely."

They followed him through the rain to a low shed. Inside stood a flat-bottomed workboat, partly covered by leaves. Its wood was rough but sound. One oar lay beneath a bench. They found another beside the wall.

"You could have mentioned this earlier," Finn said.

"I was waiting for a moment when my news would be appreciated."

They pushed the workboat into the sheltered water beside the mill. It leaked through one narrow crack, so Finn pressed a folded cloth into the gap and tied it with rope. Nora held Patch while Leo and Toby lifted the bow.

At last they were ready. They could travel only a short distance before the storm became dangerous again. Finn suggested the quiet creek on the far side of the island. Its mouth opened near a farm where they might ask for help.

The journey was slow. Rain filled the boat faster than Toby could empty it with an old tin cup. Patch sat very still, perhaps understanding at last that moving about was a poor idea. When the bank came close, Leo reached for a branch and pulled them toward dry ground.

They climbed into a field and followed a path to the home of Mrs. Miriam Cross, a widow who kept chickens and sold eggs in Bellwater. She looked at the soaked group and said nothing for a long moment.

"You children appear to have been swimming with your clothes on," she said.

"Not on purpose," Toby replied.

She brought them inside, gave them blankets, and set bowls of hot soup on the table. Patch lay in front of the fire, his wet ears spread like two brown leaves.

After hearing their story, Mrs. Cross went to an old chest and removed a folded letter. "Elias brought this to me before he disappeared. He said I should open it only if someone came looking for him with the right story."

Inside was a short message: *Miriam, if the river changes before I return, send word to Ruth Bell. The bridge accounts are false. The old records are in danger. I have seen the silver watch, and I know who orders the boats.*

"Rusk," Leo said.

"Yes," Mrs. Cross answered. "And Captain Bell has been asking questions about him for months."

She offered to take the children to the sheriff in her wagon the following morning. But before she could make another plan, a loud knock struck the front door.

Mrs. Cross lifted the lamp. A voice called from outside.

"It's Deputy Gray. Open up, Miriam. We're looking for four children who went out on the river."

The friends froze. Deputy Silas Gray had been helpful to Leo's family for years. Yet Nora had seen a silver oak-leaf pin on his coat during the spring fair. A small detail suddenly seemed important.

Mrs. Cross glanced at the letter in Leo's hand. Then she turned down the lamp and spoke in a low voice.

"There is a back door behind the pantry," she said. "Do not use the road."

The knock came again, harder this time.

"Miriam," Gray called, "I know they're inside."

And, for the first time that day, Leo was more afraid of a man on dry land than of the rising river.

VII

The Night the River Rose

Mrs. Cross opened the pantry door without making a sound. Beyond it a narrow path led between the chicken house and a row of wet apple trees. The children followed her into the darkness, carrying the notebooks and papers beneath their coats.

"Keep close to the fence," she whispered. "The road is too open."

They had taken only a dozen steps when Patch began to pull against his collar. He could hear someone coming from the far side of the garden.

"We're not alone," Finn said.

A lantern flashed among the trees. Deputy Gray had left the front door and was walking around the house. He had guessed that Mrs. Cross would try to hide them.

"This way," Leo said.

They ducked behind the chicken house and climbed over a low wall. Toby landed in a muddy hole so deep that he lost one shoe. He looked at the dark water and sighed.

"That was my good shoe."

"You only have two," Nora said.

"Exactly. A serious loss."

She reached back, pulled the shoe free, and pushed him onward. Gray's lantern passed along the fence. For a terrible moment the light rested on Patch's white back. The dog stood as still as a carved figure.

Then a thunderclap shook the valley, and Gray turned toward the house. Mrs. Cross called him from the doorway, asking loudly whether the sheriff had ordered him to

enter private homes after dark. While he argued with her, the children ran down the field and into a line of willow trees.

They did not stop until they reached the road to Bellwater. There the water was already spreading across the lowest fields. Logs and broken branches moved through the river like dark animals.

"The flood is coming faster than Father expected," Finn said. "If the water reaches the bridge supports, the old footpath will disappear."

A church bell rang from town. One long sound, then another. Soon a second bell answered from the far bank.

"The flood warning," Nora said. "We have to get people away from the water."

They hurried toward the nearest farm, where an elderly couple lived beside the lower road. The front gate was open and the chickens had climbed into a tree. Mr. Calder was trying to pull a wooden chest toward his wagon while his wife carried bedding through the rain.

"Leave the chest!" Leo called. "The water is coming over the road."

"My father's papers are in it," the old man answered.

The boys lifted the chest together. Toby pushed from behind, slipping and laughing despite the rain. With Mrs. Calder and Nora guiding them, they brought it to the higher path. They helped the couple reach Mrs. Cross's home, where other neighbours were gathering.



By then the bells were ringing all along the river.

"We should find Captain Bell," Nora said. "She'll know which boats are safe."

They reached Bellwater Landing shortly before midnight. Lanterns moved along the riverbank. The *Morning Star* was tied close to the shore, and sailors were carrying ropes and blankets onto its deck. Captain Ruth Bell stood beside the wheelhouse in a long dark coat, directing the crew.

She looked down at the four wet children and Patch.

"If you've come for a pleasure trip," she said, "you've chosen a poor evening."

Nora stepped forward and gave her Mrs. Cross's letter. Leo showed the notebook and the old receipt. Finn explained the hidden channel. Captain Bell listened with her arms crossed, asking short questions whenever one of them moved too quickly through the story.

"Why didn't you bring this to the sheriff?" she asked.

"We wanted to," Leo said. "But Deputy Gray followed us, and we know he's been helping Rusk."

Captain Bell read the letter again. "Sheriff Jonathan Bell is my brother. I trust him, but Gray has worked without telling him everything. You've done right to come to me now."

She called a sailor and sent him up the hill with a message for the sheriff. Another sailor received orders to take the Calders and their neighbours to higher ground.

"There's more," Leo said. He held out Cale's iron key. "We think Mr. Wren is in the south warehouse."

Captain Bell turned the key over in her palm. Her expression grew serious.

"The south warehouse is almost level with the river," she said. "If someone is locked inside, he may not have until morning."

A shout rose from the lower quay. A small fishing boat had broken loose and was drifting toward the bridge. Two men were trapped aboard, their oars caught beneath a floating log.

Captain Bell did not hesitate. She ordered a rescue skiff lowered from the steamboat. Finn pointed out the safer line through the water, where a line of wooden posts marked the deeper channel. The sailors used that route and reached the men before the current carried them toward the bridge.

For a few minutes everyone watched in silence. Then the skiff returned, with both fishermen safe beneath blankets. Toby gave one of them the last piece of his pie. The man held it in both hands as though it were a small treasure.

"I had plans for that pie," Toby murmured.

"You've become a hero," Nora told him.

"I would rather be a hero with supper."

Soon the sheriff arrived. He was a tall, tired man with mud on his boots. He listened to his sister, read Mr. Wren's writing, and examined the receipts. Then he asked Leo where Deputy Gray had last been seen.

"At Mrs. Cross's house. He knew we had the papers."

The sheriff's face hardened. "He told me he was checking flood damage. I did not send him after children."

Captain Bell held up the key. "I think we have a man to rescue and a warehouse to open."

The river struck the landing with a heavy sound. Water rushed between the planks, and the lowest steps disappeared.

Leo looked toward the row of dark warehouses beneath the bridge. One small window shone above the water. As he watched, a shadow crossed it, then vanished.

He grabbed Finn's arm.

"Someone is still inside."

At that moment the light went out.

VIII

The Locked Warehouse

The south warehouse stood at the end of a narrow quay, where the current pressed against its wooden supports. It had once been used to store grain. Now Thomas Rusk rented it for tools, building supplies, and river cargo.

Captain Bell would not allow the children to enter first. She placed two sailors beside the door, while Sheriff Bell examined the lock. Rain struck the roof so hard that their voices seemed to come from far away.

"Gate Two," Finn said, pointing to the painted number beside the entrance.

The iron key turned, but the door did not open. Something heavy had been pushed against it from the other side.

"Stand back," the sheriff ordered.

The sailors forced the door with a long wooden bar. A pile of empty crates fell inward. Dark water washed across the floor, carrying bits of straw and paper. The smell of wet wood filled the room.

A staircase rose along the back wall. Above it came a faint knocking sound.

"Elias!" Leo called before he could stop himself.

"Leo?" came a weak voice. "Is that you?"

Leo had never been so pleased to hear a man's voice.

The sailors climbed the stairs and found Elias Wren in a small locked office. He was thinner than before, with a bandage around one hand, but he was alive. Captain Bell gave him water and helped him sit beside an open window.

"I thought I'd have to learn to swim through a wall," he said, trying to smile.

"You weren't going to leave without paying for the boat you lost," Leo replied.

Mr. Wren laughed, then coughed. "A fair complaint."

When the sheriff asked what had happened, Mr. Wren spoke slowly. Rusk had asked him to carry money for the bridge workers. The bags were sealed, and Wren had been told to deliver them to the north landing. When he opened one in front of a witness, he discovered that it contained stones, not coins. The real wages had been removed before the bags reached him.

Wren had copied the accounts and planned to speak to the sheriff. But Cale and another man had taken his boat, held him at the old mill on Cinder Island, and later moved him to the south warehouse. His papers had been hidden before his capture.

"I left the brass tube in my boat," he said. "I hoped the river would bring it to someone who knew me."

"It did," Leo answered. "The river took its time."

"Rivers do," Mr. Wren said. "So do people."

While Captain Bell checked his injuries, the sheriff searched the office. He found no ledger, only a desk, two chairs, and a cupboard full of damp rope. On the wall behind the desk hung a portrait of Rusk in a heavy wooden frame.

Nora noticed four fresh nail marks around the frame. "Someone moved that recently," she said.

The sheriff lifted it from the wall. Behind it was a shallow space cut into the boards. A large red book lay inside, wrapped in dark cloth.

"The main ledger," Finn whispered.



Sheriff Bell opened it. The first pages listed honest payments. Farther inside, the writing changed. Several workers' names appeared twice, and large sums had been marked as delivered when no money had reached them. A page near the centre carried the number 17 and Rusk's signature.

"This may be enough," the sheriff said. "But we still need witnesses."

"You have one," said a voice from the doorway.

Edwin Cale stood between the sailors, soaked to the skin. He had come willingly with them from the quay. His eyes fell on Mr. Wren, and he looked down.

"I'm sorry, Elias. I thought they'd scare you into giving up the copy. I never thought they would lock you here."

Mr. Wren studied him. "You could have let me go."

"I know."

Cale gave the sheriff a folded paper. It listed the dates when the money had been moved from the bridge office to Rusk's warehouse. It also named Deputy Gray as the man who had been paid to keep questions away from the sheriff.

"Why tell us now?" the sheriff asked.

"Because I heard the water rising against the warehouse," Cale said. "And I couldn't stand another hour wondering whether Elias would drown because I was too frightened to speak."

The sheriff took the statement and told a sailor to keep Cale with him. Cale did not argue.

They were leading Mr. Wren toward the door when a shout came from outside. Thomas Rusk had arrived in a covered wagon. He was trying to turn it around, but floodwater had reached the horses' knees. Beside him stood Deputy Gray, holding a lantern and a leather bag.

Sheriff Bell walked into the rain with the red ledger beneath his coat.

"Mr. Rusk," he called, "you will stay here and answer some questions. Deputy Gray, hand me your badge."

Gray looked at the rising water, then at the sailors surrounding the wagon. He put his badge into the sheriff's hand.

Rusk attempted to smile. "Sheriff, there's been a mistake. Those books are private company papers."

"No," said the sheriff. "They concern public money and workers who have gone without wages."

Rusk's smile disappeared. "You have no proof I took it."

At that moment Toby stepped forward. The leather bag in Gray's hand had broken open. Several rolls of coins spilled into the mud. Each roll carried a paper label printed with **Bellwater Bridge Fund**.

"Then these must be someone else's lunch," Toby said.

Even one of the sailors laughed.

The sheriff ordered the men to take Rusk and Gray to the higher road. Mr. Wren was helped onto the rescue boat, and the sailors pulled clear of the quay just as a section of the warehouse wall cracked under the current.

Leo watched the building fade into the rain. For three weeks he had imagined Mr. Wren lying somewhere beneath the river. Now the old man sat beside him, wrapped in a blanket, breathing slowly.

"You left us a very difficult puzzle," Leo said.

"I left it for people who would keep asking questions," Mr. Wren answered.

Patch placed his wet head on the old man's knee. Mr. Wren scratched behind the dog's ear.

"And for a good dog," he added.

"He helped," Finn said.

"He also ate half our food," Toby observed.

"That," said Mr. Wren, "sounds exactly like Patch."

Above the river the storm finally began to move east. Between the clouds appeared one narrow line of dawn.

IX

The Bells of Bellwater

The rain stopped before sunrise. Bellwater looked different in the pale light. Mud lay across the quay, and the lower streets were covered with broken branches. Here and there a chimney still smoked above a house surrounded by water. People stood at their doors, watching the river as if it might decide to return.

Captain Bell ordered her crew to carry food and blankets to the families on the higher bank. Sheriff Bell sent two men to guard the warehouses and asked the bridge workers to meet him at the town hall before noon.

"Will they believe us?" Leo asked Mr. Wren, who was resting beneath a blanket in the captain's cabin.

"They do not have to believe every word we say," Wren answered. "They will see the papers and hear the witnesses. That is why keeping records matters."

Finn looked pleased. This was exactly the sort of lesson he liked.

"I always said a notebook was useful," he told Toby.

"I always said bread was useful," Toby replied. "And I notice everybody wants bread today."

Nora and Mrs. Quill were preparing baskets of food for the flooded houses. Leo helped carry them across the upper road. Patch joined the work with great excitement, although he was unable to understand why no one allowed him to carry the sausages.

At the town hall a crowd had gathered. Some were angry. Others were simply tired. Joseph Dyer, the bridge worker Leo had met earlier, stood near the entrance. His wife held their youngest child's hand. They had waited six weeks for money that the accounts said had already been paid.

Sheriff Bell stood on the hall steps with the red ledger. He spoke slowly so that everyone could hear.

"We found evidence that money meant for the bridge workers was taken before it reached them. The records will be examined by the court. Until then, no one should blame the workers or Elias Wren for the missing wages."

A man in the crowd shouted, "How do we know the money wasn't spent?"

"You will be shown the figures," the sheriff replied. "You can ask questions, and we will answer what we know."

He invited Joseph Dyer to compare his note with Payment Number 17. Finn had copied the date of the receipt into his notebook. Nora had kept the original list of measurements, which helped show where the false receipt had been hidden. The two papers belonged to different parts of the mystery, but together they showed how carefully Rusk's men had planned their work.



A thin man near the back raised his hand. "I saw those boxes taken aboard the *Morning Star*," he said. "I helped load them. They were much heavier than bridge tools should be."

Captain Bell came forward. "And my crew kept the loading records. I will give those to the sheriff as well."

Leo felt a strange relief. When they had first found the boat, the whole mystery seemed to rest on the four friends. Now other people were speaking, remembering, and bringing their own pieces of truth. The puzzle was becoming a public record instead of a secret carried in a boy's pocket.

Mr. Wren arrived with Mrs. Cross. He walked slowly, leaning on a stick. The crowd fell quiet as he climbed the steps.

"I know some of you thought I had run away with the money," he said. "I cannot blame you for being afraid. But I hope that, next time, we will ask one another questions before we decide who is guilty."

Joseph Dyer stepped forward and shook his hand. "I'm sorry, Elias."

"You had a family to feed," Wren replied. "I understand why you were worried."

After the meeting, the sheriff showed the children a small metal box found in Rusk's wagon. Inside were the missing payment seals and several notes with Gray's signature. The documents would be kept with the ledger until the court could examine them.

"This does not finish the case," the sheriff explained. "There will be questions, witnesses, and a fair hearing. But your care with those little clues has helped us begin."

Nora looked toward the busy square. "The bridge still needs repairing."

"And the workers still need their wages," Finn said.

"Which means the town has work left to do," Leo added.

Toby listened to them, then held up the empty food basket. "I can begin with the bakery. The town has also finished every roll we brought."

That evening, the church bells rang again. This time there was no storm warning. The bells marked the return of the river ferry and the opening of the upper road. People gathered by the bridge, waving to the little boat as it crossed the quiet water.

Leo stood beside Nora, Finn, and Toby. Patch leaned against his leg. In the distance the sun broke through the clouds, touching the flooded fields with a soft, golden light.

"It almost looks peaceful," Finn said.

"It is peaceful," Nora replied. "For now."

Toby nodded solemnly. "Then let us enjoy it before somebody finds another mysterious box."

Leo laughed. The river was still full of things he did not know, and the world beyond Bellwater was larger than he had ever imagined. But for the first time in weeks, he did not feel that every unknown thing was a threat.

Some were simply places waiting to be explored.

X

A Promise at Daybreak

Three days later the Cedar River had fallen enough for the main road to open. Mud covered the lower streets, and several fences had been washed away, but the bridge remained standing. Families worked together to clean their homes. The bakery gave out bread to people who had lost their kitchens in the flood.

The news about Thomas Rusk travelled farther than the flood. Sheriff Bell had questioned the workers, checked the money rolls, and compared the red ledger with Mr. Wren's copies. The false payments were clear. Rusk and Deputy Gray would face a court, and the bridge fund could finally be returned to the people it belonged to.

Cale had admitted helping to keep Mr. Wren a prisoner. The sheriff thanked him for speaking, but explained that telling the truth did not erase what he had done. Cale accepted that answer without protest.

On Saturday morning the four friends visited Mr. Wren at his small house above Bellwater Landing. He was sitting in a wooden chair, repairing a fishing net with one hand while Patch slept beneath his feet.

"You should be resting," Nora told him.

"This is resting," he replied. "If I sat still all day, I would have to listen to my thoughts. They are not always interesting."

Toby put a basket on the table. "Mrs. Finch sent bread. And I have brought a pie to celebrate your return."

Mr. Wren raised an eyebrow. "A whole pie?"

"Nearly a whole pie," Toby admitted.

They laughed, and for a while the house felt as ordinary as it had before the mystery. But Leo had brought the first unfinished note in his pocket. He unfolded it and placed it beside the net.

"You never finished this," he said. "What were you trying to tell us?"

Mr. Wren read the words slowly: *Do not trust the man who—*

He shook his head. "I meant to write, 'Do not trust the man who tells you that honest questions are dangerous.' I heard footsteps outside the mill before I could finish. I had only enough time to hide the paper."

"Cale said something like that at the landing," Nora said.

"Fear can make a person obey the wrong orders," Mr. Wren answered. "It is useful to notice when someone asks you not to think."

Finn opened his notebook. It was nearly full. Between weather observations and river depths he had written times, names, questions, and small facts that had seemed unimportant when he first noticed them.

"I was wrong about several things," he said.

"So was I," Nora replied. "I thought the three knocks were a message from Mr. Wren. They were used by the men hiding the money."



"I thought the box on the boat held treasure," Toby said. "And in a way it did. It held the workers' wages."

Leo looked toward the river. "I thought we could solve everything ourselves. When the flood came, we needed the captain, the sheriff, and half the town."

Mr. Wren nodded. "Being brave doesn't mean refusing help. It means doing what is right, even when you must admit that you cannot do it alone."

Later they walked down to the landing. The green rowing boat had been repaired and lay tied to the strongest post. Finn had replaced the damaged board. Leo had painted over the scratches. Toby had offered advice from a safe distance, which everyone agreed had been his most useful contribution.

A small crowd had gathered to watch the *Morning Star* return to service. Captain Bell stood at the upper rail, waving to the people along the quay. The workers on the bridge raised their hats as the steamboat passed.

"You know," Toby said, "we could take the skiff upstream next week. There's a little island near the willow bend where my uncle says the fishing is excellent."

"No secret tunnels?" Finn asked.

"Not that I know of."

"No stolen money?" Nora asked.

"I certainly hope not."

"No mysterious men in dark coats?" Leo added.

Toby thought for a moment. "There might be a mysterious fisherman in a brown hat. But I expect he will only be mysterious because he doesn't share his bait."

They agreed that a quiet trip would be pleasant. Nora wanted to collect plants for the school garden. Finn wanted to measure the depth near the willow bend. Leo hoped to spend an afternoon on the water without being followed. Toby wanted to catch fish and eat the rest of the pie.

Patch was the only one who made no plan. He had already discovered a new smell beside the landing and was following it with complete confidence.

As the sun climbed higher, the boys and Nora stood together beside the old green boat. The water was brown after the storm, but it moved calmly between the banks. A group of ducks crossed in front of them, leaving silver lines on the surface.

Leo took the little brass tube from his pocket. Inside it was now a new strip of paper. He had written only one sentence:

If we get lost, remember that we can ask for help.

He put the tube in the boat's small wooden box, where they kept the spare rope and a dry match tin. It was not a secret message or a warning. It was a promise they could all understand.

"Ready?" Finn asked.

"Ready," Nora said.

"Nearly," Toby replied, reaching into the basket for one last piece of bread.

Patch jumped into the boat before anyone could stop him. His tail struck the side with three quick knocks.

The friends stared at each other.

Then they began to laugh.

On the Cedar River, even an ordinary morning could sound like the beginning of another story.

THE END

Glossary

Forty useful words and expressions from the story. Read the explanation, then find the word in its chapter.

bank
land beside a river

landing
a place where boats stop

current
moving water in a river

reeds
tall plants growing in wet places

oar
a long tool used to move a small boat

bow
the front of a boat

shallow
not deep

skiff
a small, light boat

channel
a passage of water a boat can travel through

bend
a place where a river turns

ferry
a boat that carries people across water

quay
a built area where boats load and unload

cargo
goods carried by a boat or vehicle

warehouse
a building for keeping goods

merchant
a person who buys and sells goods

receipt
a paper showing a payment

wages
money paid for work

ledger
a book containing financial records

account
a written record of money

sealed
closed so that it cannot easily be opened

witness
a person who sees an event happen

sheriff
the main law officer of a local area

deputy
someone who works for and helps an official

suspect
to believe something may be true

vanish
to disappear suddenly

signal
a sign or sound used to send a message

lantern
a lamp that can be carried

whistle
a small object that makes a high sound

survey
to measure land or water carefully

mill
a building where machines process materials

oilcloth
cloth made to keep water out

ivy
a climbing green plant

flood
water that spreads over normally dry land

rescue
to save someone from danger

bandage
cloth put on an injury

conscience
a person's sense of right and wrong

evidence
facts or objects that help show what happened

courage
the strength to act despite fear

promise
a statement that you will do something

trust
to believe someone is honest and dependable

Reading Check

1. What was unusual about the boat Leo found at Bellwater Landing?

2. Why did Leo believe Elias Wren had not stolen the bridge money?

3. What was hidden inside the brass tube?

4. How did Nora help the boys understand the river measurements?

5. What did the friends hear at the abandoned north landing?

6. Why did the boxes marked as bridge tools seem suspicious?

7. What did the friends find beneath the stone wall on Cinder Island?

8. Why was Edwin Cale afraid of Thomas Rusk?

9. How did the rising river change the friends' plans?

10. Who helped the children after they reached Bellwater during the flood?

11. Where was Elias Wren being held, and how was he rescued?

12. What evidence helped the sheriff investigate the stolen wages?

13. Why did Nora and Finn keep notes and documents?

14. What did Elias mean by saying honest questions should not be feared?

15. How did Toby bring humour into difficult moments?

16. What did the friends learn about courage and asking for help?

Discuss and Write

Discussion

1. Was it right for the friends to begin their search without telling an adult? Explain your view.

2. Which character would you trust most? Give two reasons from the story.

3. Can someone like Edwin Cale do something wrong and still choose to help later?

4. Which scene made you feel the most tension? Why?

5. How does the river act as both a danger and a source of hope in the story?

6. What can a town do when false information harms an innocent person?

Writing Task

Write a 180-250 word diary entry from Nora, Finn, Leo, or Toby. Describe one day of the adventure. Include what your character saw, how they felt, the decision they made, and what they learned.

Reading Reflection

Choose five new words from the glossary. Use each in an original sentence connected to the story or to your own life.

WorldVoice Library

The Boys of the Cedar River

This graded reader includes:

- A captivating and realistic story
- Ten illustrated chapters
- A glossary of key vocabulary (40 words)
- Comprehension and discussion questions
- A writing task

English Level
B1
Intermediate



WorldVoice Library
Read · Learn · Explore

9 781234 567916